

weekend

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metroPLUS THE HINDU

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In his book *Man-Eaters of Kumaon*, Jim Corbett recounts following the alarm call of a langur – “khek-khek-khekerr” – to track a tiger. Today, almost every naturalist and self-taught wildlife photographer will tell you the same thing: your eyes, ears and nose are your best guides when searching for the bird or snake that drew you to the forest.

Wildlife tourism in India is booming. According to business consulting firm Grand View Research, the wildlife tourism market in India was valued at about \$11.2 billion (over ₹1,100 crore) in 2023 and is projected to grow at around 10% annually until 2030.

During the peak season (November to April), national parks receive a steady stream of visitors. A jeep safari with armed forest guards is one way to experience the wild. But there is another approach: travelling with birders, naturalists and photographers who help visitors understand the flora, fauna and subtle signals of the forest.

In Assam’s Dima Hasao district lies Hajong Gajam (Hajong Lake), the only known natural habitat for rare and endangered freshwater turtles and hill terrapins. Reaching this biodiversity heritage site requires navigating narrow paths through dense bamboo thickets. The village headman, Joypen Kemprai, guides visitors along the route, helping them avoid the giant webs of tiger spiders that thrive in the damp forest.

From a watchtower overlooking the lake, we waited for a glimpse of a tortoise. Joypen used the pause to explain the forest. “The bamboo you see keeps this area moist, creating the right environment for tortoises,” he said. “Some of these trees are more than 200-years-old.” After about 20 minutes – and a short lesson in bamboo ecology – a tortoise finally emerged to sunbathe. Without Joypen’s knowledge, the moment would have meant far less. He charges nothing for guiding visitors. “Without understanding,” he says, “the forest remains hidden.”

Inspired by such efforts, several young people in Dima Hasao now accompany visitors – not merely as guides but as educators. They introduce travellers to local experiences, such as sipping tea brewed and served in fresh bamboo tubes at the Bendao Baglai waterfall, one of the region’s distinctive treks. Trips here are often organised by Guwahati-based travel organiser Naushad Hussain, who works with local youth to help visitors understand the landscape.

If you are looking for adventure that is not confined to a park, mountaineer and certified instructor Shekhar Bordoloi hosts tourists at his wild retreat in Nagaon, Assam. “Nothing is fancy here, because the experience with the wild is all about closeness to



Front row at the jungle

Travellers are moving beyond jeep safaris to explore forests with naturalists who teach them how to decode bird calls, animal behaviour, and understand landscapes

Nature. We take visitors to a wild waterfall, on hikes, and rappelling in the natural environment. The cost for camping varies from ₹1,000 (without activities) to ₹2,500 with rappelling.”

Understand the terrain
In Ladakh, Hyderabad-based photographer Ismail Shariff has spent years camping at 3,600 metres in search of the elusive snow leopard. Using a Swarovski BTX spotting scope, which offers true-to-life images and the comfort required for long-term observation, he now hosts expeditions for visitors from Singapore, the UK, the US and Switzerland. Most are not photographers; they simply hope to glimpse the rare mountain cat.

Ismail began organising such trips after joining one himself in 2017. It took him nearly two years to see his first snow leopard. Today, his team includes experienced spotters who track the animal’s movements across the terrain. The cost involved in going on a snow leopard expedition can cost upwards of ₹1,75,000 for an 11-day expedition.

He also added, “Expeditions like

these are multi-layered,” he says. “They’re not just about sightseeing.” Interest grew through requests on his Instagram page. “When the enquiries kept coming, I realised there was demand. Now, I organise expeditions to Spiti and Leh twice a year.” Ismail is clear about ethics: conservation, he says, should never involve baiting wildlife for photographs.

Spotting a snow leopard is extremely tricky because it blends well with the environment they are found in. Ismail explains, “Spotting a snow leopard is less about finding a cat, and more about convincing your eyes that the mountain has quietly grown whiskers.”

For Bengaluru-based wildlife photographer Koushik Chattopadhyay, the first lesson is learning to read the forest – listening to bird calls, watching subtle movements and understanding animal behaviour.

For Koushik, who works in IT, photography began as a way to observe wildlife closely. Over time, friends and fellow enthusiasts began

joining him on field trips. Those informal outings from 2022 gradually evolved into organised journeys centred on respectful wildlife observation and photography.

He keeps his groups small – never more than eight participants. “Planning begins with the season, animal activity and the skill levels of participants,” he explains. “I coordinate logistics, permits, safety measures and ethical guidelines so the experience remains respectful to wildlife.” Koushik’s favourite destinations include Wayanad and Munnar in Kerala for their biodiversity, and the tiger reserves of Madhya Pradesh for big-cat sightings. Internationally, he recommends Yala National Park (Sri Lanka) and Maasai Mara National Reserve (Kenya) for wildlife encounters.

Koushik does not charge for trips, as most participants are friends or colleagues. But he says if one were to sign up with other guides, costs may vary depending on the destination and duration. A four-day macro photography trip – or ‘herping’ – in Munnar or Wayanad may cost between ₹30,000 and 45,000 per person. A Masai Mara safari can cost around ₹1.9 lakh per person for a couple of days, while a series of

tiger safaris in India may range between ₹30,000 and ₹40,000 per person for eight drives.

Off the beaten track

Such journeys often lead travellers to lesser-known landscapes – places that are neither sanctuaries nor safari parks. As Assam-based naturalist, wildlife biologist and conservationist Nilutpal Mahanta points out, these locations also avoid the practice of baiting wildlife for close-up sightings.

Nilutpal says the Northeast’s biodiversity is often overshadowed by its most famous species, the Indian rhinoceros. “Nearly 45% of migratory birds visit the Northeast, yet conversations focus only on rhinos,” he says. He frequently takes student groups and birdwatchers into the field – not to teach photography but to help them observe birds in their natural habitats.

He is glad that hide tourism – specialised setups offering close wildlife views for photographers – has not taken root in Assam. “I want visitors to feel the thrill of trekking eight kilometres to see the bird they have been hoping to find,” he says.

Nilutpal’s treks often expand beyond birds. At Eaglenest Wildlife Sanctuary, in the Himalayan foothills of West Kameng District, Arunachal Pradesh, he introduced students to pteridophytes and bryophytes – primitive plants that help break down rock and form soil. “I asked them to touch the rocks,” he recalls. “When the sandy residue stuck to their hands, I explained how bryophytes work.”

His favourite birding destinations include Eaglenest, Namdapha Tiger Reserve, Mishmi Hills, Dihing Patkai, Nameri, Panbari near Kaziranga National Park and Garbhanga near Guwahati – landscapes known for rare migratory birds. Naturalists leading such trips typically charge between ₹7,000 and ₹8,000 per person per day.

Travel with these storytellers, conservationists and educators, and you begin to see why those who understand a forest are more likely to protect it than those who merely pass through.



pick of the week



Bite into Asia

For all things Pan-Asian, Lotus at The Park Chennai is serving a refreshed menu by Chef Thomas Mahara. Known as one of the first Thai dining restaurants in the city, the new menu brings classics with inventive signatures. Try dishes like Japanese kanikama poke taco, dynamite prawns, nori wrapped cottage cheese steaks, Bangkok bass, lotus fried rice, and black sticky rice and lychees. At Lotus, The Park, Nungambakkam. For reservations, call 9884401601.



Sari fit check

Premam Silks, by Chennai-based entrepreneur Swarnamugi Raghupathy, debuts with a two-day showcase. Think heirloom weaves with a new spin. Choose from Benaras and Kanjeevaram silks, bandhini Paithanis, organza-bordered drapes, Paithani lehengas, and Benaras salwar suits. Priced ₹10,000 onwards. April 2 and 3 from 11am to 8pm at The Folly, Amethyst, Royapettah.



Kanan in the house

Quick wit, relatable chaos, and just the right dose of existential humour, Kanan Gill is back on stage with his latest live set, Not this Again. He shot to fame with the Pretentious Movie Review series, on YouTube. At this 90-minute laugh fest expect Kanan's absurd takes on everyday life, and that signature dry delivery for comedy that is chaotic, and a little too real. On April 11, 8pm onwards at MS Subbulakshmi Auditorium. Tickets starting ₹999 on bookmyshow.com



Indie vibes only

Lights, camera, community! The Indie Frame returns with its sixth Chennai Chapter Meet, screening Kettenreaktion by Akhil Jayashree, Thalaiyatti (Bobblehead) by Arun Rengaswamy, and Jodi (IF) by Tathagata Ghosh. Grab your spot, meet fellow artistes, and soak in an evening where storytelling and collaboration take centrestage. On March 28, 5pm onwards at Backyard, Adyar. Tickets ₹200, registration on theindieframe.in



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The last few years have seen a revival of Tamil Nadu's tourism hotspots, Chettinad in particular. This, courtesy of festivals like the annual The Chettinad Heritage & Cultural Festival, culinary tours, architectural initiatives in the region, and more. Now, this list gets another addition by way of Kalai, a Chettinad Art and Architecture Festival that launches this April.

Curated by The Lotus Palace Chettinad in collaboration with a few of Chettinad's most iconic heritage properties such as The Bangala, Visalam, Chidambara Vilas, Chettinad Mansion and Saratha Vilas, "Kalai was born from a vision to celebrate and preserve Chettinad's legacy through immersive cultural experiences," says Priya Paul, chairperson, Apeejay Surrendra Park Hotels. "My connection with Chettinad goes back over a decade, long before I envisioned a hotel here. I was drawn to its stories, architectural grandeur, and extraordinary craftsmanship. To me, Chettinad offers travellers a chance to discover its nuanced historical narratives and meaningful cultural experiences," she adds. "The idea for Kalai grew organically from Suvai, our food-focussed festival held in July last year," says Kathiravan Karumanithi, hotel manager, The Lotus Palace Chettinad. "While guests deeply

Art in motion

Inside Kalai, Chettinad's latest three-day festival of expert-led talks, temple tours and craft experiences



enjoyed the culinary experiences, what truly captivated them was the architecture, craftsmanship, and artistic detailing of the spaces they explored across Chettinad," explains Kathiravan, adding that it is this response that sparked the vision for Kalai – a festival dedicated to showcasing the region's art and architecture through curated, immersive experiences.

Like Suvai, Kalai is intended to be

an annual affair "with each edition evolving to offer new perspectives and experiences that celebrate the depth and diversity of Chettinad". Work on the first edition began in October 2025, "with a clear focus on creating meaningful access to Chettinad's lesser-seen spaces, along with expert-led insights that bring alive its unique confluence of architecture, art, and craftsmanship," he explains.

(Right) Chef René Redzepi; (below) former Noma employee Jason Ignacio White holds a sign that reads "Noma broke me" during a protest in Los Angeles. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK



Amid ongoing debates around Noma Chef René Redzepi, a closer look at the power dynamics, pressure, and the true cost behind the pursuit of culinary excellence

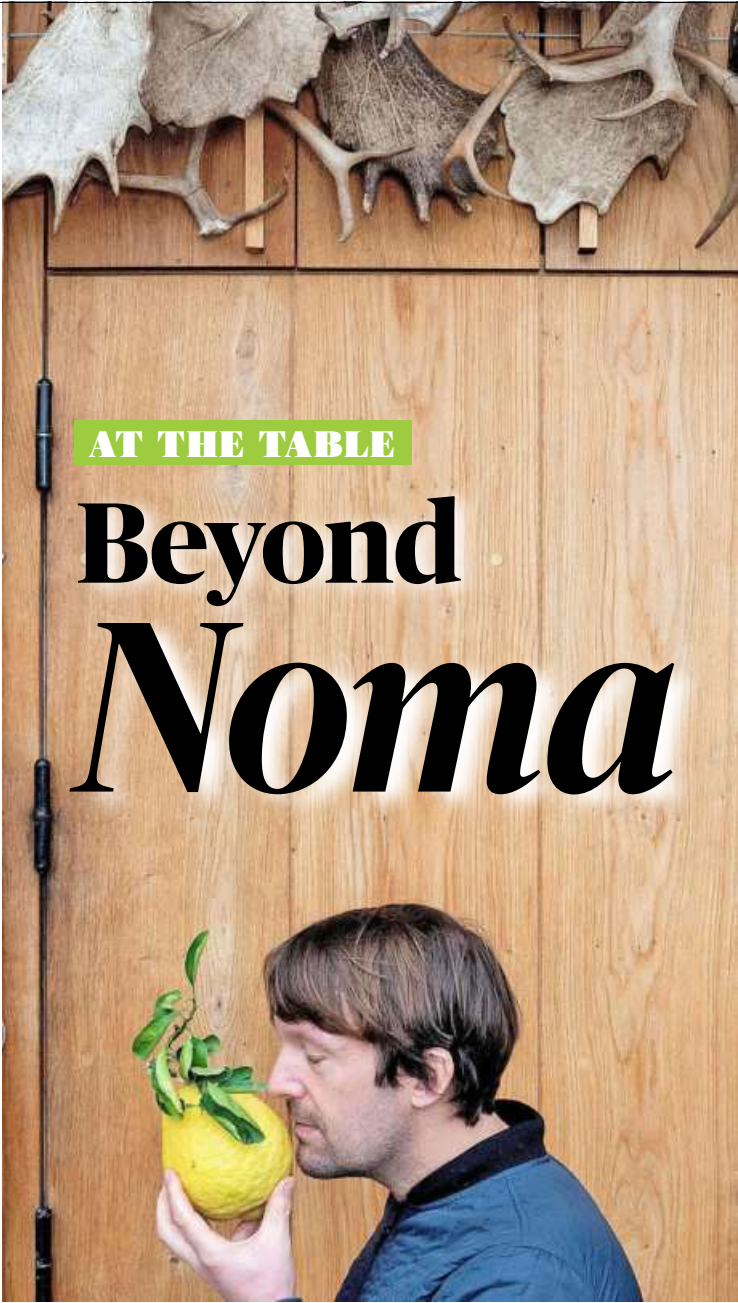
Karan Gokani

The recent conversation around toxic kitchen culture, prompted by stories around the Michelin-starred Danish restaurant Noma and its Chef René Redzepi, has pushed the inner workings of restaurant kitchens into public view. For the record, I have never eaten at Noma, nor do I know anything of its internal culture, so I am less interested in commenting on one chef or one restaurant than on what this moment reveals about our industry.

For long, the professional kitchen has carried a certain mythology: high stakes, machismo, alpha personalities, and a relentless fight to survive. Popular culture feeds that image. Anthony Bourdain's Kitchen Confidential romanticises the kitchen as a pirate ship. The Bear, Hell's Kitchen, Boiling Point and

Burnt all play with the same idea – brilliance and volatility are natural companions. In that sense, what we are seeing now is less a revelation than a tipping point. From inside the industry, though, the picture is more nuanced. For over a decade, I have run, cooked in, visited and collaborated with plenty of kitchens that do not carry these undertones. That is not to say kitchens are loving, gentle places. Nor are banks, law firms, hospitals, ad agencies or production houses.

Any high-functioning workplace comes with stress, hierarchy and pressure. Kitchens simply add their own special ingredients to the mix. Physical labour, heat, speed, irregular work hours, neurodivergent personalities and the daily challenge of producing something excellent. It is, in many ways, the perfect storm. Within that storm, I have seen different kinds of leadership.



AT THE TABLE

Beyond Noma

There are chefs who came up the hard way and feel their position gives them the licence to do the same to others. It is often framed as tough love, not unlike ragging or hazing at university. Then there are chefs who went through exactly that world and decided it stops with them. The kitchen can be serious, but fear, humiliation and bullying have no place in it.

I think we make a mistake by talking about restaurants as though they are all one thing. A 30-seat, \$1,000 tasting-menu restaurant is a different beast from the one turning 1,000 covers a day at \$30 a plate. Both create experiences, one

aspirational and the other accessible. But, their psychology is not the same. In the world of stars and rankings, there is often an almost spiritual belief that sacrifice – surrendering time, money, relationships, health and sometimes self-respect – is the price of recognition. There is a certain romance to that idea. The boxer sacrifices brain cells, the Olympian sacrifices childhood, and the monk withdraws from family and worldly life. Greatness, in this view, demands suffering. The danger, however, comes when a young cook also starts to believe that being bullied is somehow part of the journey. In more grounded kitchens,

especially those operating on fair pay, staff retention and accessible dining, things tend to work differently. People know their worth, know they have options and will leave if the culture is poor. Those alone change behaviour at the top.

So, is there a solution? I am not sure there is one neat answer, because restaurants are too varied and too personal for that. But respect should be non-negotiable. In the end, it's not only the restaurants, but awards bodies, sponsors, the media and ultimately the diners who decide what gets celebrated and glorified. They need to ask the questions that matter.

The real question is what we choose to reward. Do we continue to treat absolute perfection on the plate as the ultimate goal, quietly accepting that young chefs may feel any price is worth paying to reach it? Or do we begin to recognise and reward organisations that produce great food while also creating fairer, healthier workplaces? I do not claim there is a simple answer. Many of the world's most intricate restaurants operate with reverence for produce, craft and people. But those same environments can sometimes allow unhealthy cultures to hide behind the pursuit of brilliance.

In many ways the choice is no different from standing in a supermarket aisle deciding between two bars of chocolate or two bags of coffee. One carries a fair-trade label. The other sits wrapped in shiny gold foil, its supply chain harder to decipher. In that moment we decide what matters. We can turn a blind eye to exploitation, or we can reward fairness with our wallets. Restaurants are no different. What we celebrate ultimately shapes the culture of the industry.

Karan Gokani is a London-based chef and restaurateur who spends his time cooking, travelling and exploring what the world is eating. He loves the gym, biryani and his frying pan. Not necessarily in that order.

Beyond croissants

At Abov, in Puducherry, Chef Vivek Ravi's menu features lesser-known Asian dishes

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I travelled to Puducherry for what might be one of the best pan-Asian meals I have had in a while. At Abov – a relatively new rooftop restaurant at The Residency Towers, I am reminded that the city's food scene is now stretching beyond its famed boulangeries.

Enter Abov, where you have to temper expectations of a cinematic, sea-facing view, given its location amid the bustling market lanes of Anna Salai. We start with hibiscus tea, a warm prelude to the meals ahead. First up, we try Sri Lankan edamame curried soup, the tender edamame bits paired well with the coconut-heavy broth.

The menu travels through Malaysia, Myanmar, Vietnam, Burma and Sri Lanka – a deliberate choice, says Chef Vivek Ravi.

The lephet thoke or Burmese pickled tea leaf salad is a testament to that. Shredded cabbage is mixed with crunchy fried lentils, fermented tea leaves, roasted quinoa and sesame seeds. Fermented tea leaves in a salad may sound unusual at first, but here they lend a gentle, earthy depth that rounds out the dish rather than overpowering it. Next up, we try ivy gourd

dim sum – a vegetable I hated as a child. Despite my initial scepticism, I end up polishing off a plate in no time. The filling is mashed to a soft, almost creamy consistency; then tucked inside a dumpling and doused with chilli oil.

The beverage menu offers a mix of familiar classic cocktails and house signatures. From the latter, the chef insists on the matcha clarified cocktail, which brings together, amongst other things, gin, dry martini, pineapple juice, matcha, and yoghurt-dehydrated banana. Beef rendang, Sri Lankan ambul thiyai, and prawn murungakkai curry arrive for the mains, all paired with white rice. The beef rendang is tender and flavourful in every bite, a result of slow cooking for over six hours. The prawn curry is hearty and coconutty, which asks for multiple servings.

Dessert arrives as a work of art: Jasmine panna cotta, served with a side of chardonay and lemongrass sorbet. There are other options like matcha cheesecake, chocolate mousse, hazelnut tart, and more – all bookmarked for our next trip.

₹3,500 for two (including alcohol). 388, Anna Salai, Subbarayapillai Chathiram. For more details, call 9600055635.



Abov, Puducherry. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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When cricketing legend Sachin Tendulkar first saw tigress Junabai in the buffer zone of Madnapur at the Tadoba-Andhari Tiger Reserve in Maharashtra, Sunil Mehta, pioneer of the COCOON community-based Nature conservancy model, told him that he had “just licked the opium”. He added, “When you go back to your busy schedule in Mumbai, you will start missing it here. You will come back again, and again, and again.” That’s the power of the tiger.”

Sachin has been frequenting Tadoba and Gothangaon for tiger safaris, most recently in November 2024 for the 10th anniversary of Sunil’s The Bamboo Forest safari lodge in Tadoba.

If comparing the thrill of tiger safaris with an opioid high seems like a stretch, it only takes an afternoon at the Umred Pauni Karhandla Wildlife Sanctuary, Maharashtra, to understand the pull. Minutes after you reach the sanctuary’s Gothangaon gate, the guide announces loudly, “Tiger sighting has started. Please hold on,” as he hops onto the safari vehicle. For the next 20 minutes, you hold onto dear life as you drive through the rocky terrain, big spider webs and skewed-off twines. “It’s all part of the experience,” you are assured.

But the safaris are not just about high-speed *Jumanji* rides. As Arjun Manjunath, associate director, The Bamboo Forest Nature Conservancy, puts it, “The thrill is in what happens before you see a tiger.” Unlike African safaris – where there are open savannas, and animals can be seen from kilometres away – here, you need to search for a tiger, he adds.

On safaris, guides and naturalists use pugmarks on the soil and animal calls. “From the smallest bird to the largest elephant, every species announces the presence of this powerful animal. Keep your eyes, ears, and senses open,” says Arjun.

Ankita Pathak has been working for over a year as a naturalist at The Bamboo Forest Nature Conservancy in Gothangaon. She says, “Peacocks give calls when they spot leopards. Rufous treepeeps give alarm calls when they see tigers. So it’s not just about tigers – it’s about understanding birds, herbivores, small mammals, and insects.”

“The whole purpose of us accompanying guests is to convert them into ambassadors of wildlife conservation,” pitches in Arjun, adding that safaris also attract many through which private entities like The Bamboo Forest facilitate CSR activities to help the local



Chasing stripes in Tadoba

Wildlife enthusiasts at The Bamboo Forest Experience on how the Tadoba-Andhari Tiger Reserve and the Umred Pauni Karhandla Wildlife Sanctuary are hotspots to sight the big cat

Sunil reminisces about how a trip to the Sariska Tiger Reserve as a child changed his life forever. “Later, when the Sariska poaching happened” – when it was revealed that the reserve that had 16 tigers in 2002 was left with zero tigers by 2005 – “I was shocked.” That ushered in everything that followed for Sunil, including the founding of The Bamboo Forest Experience.

Sunil stresses how seeing a tiger in a zoo comes nowhere close to seeing it in its own natural habitat. Arjun and Sunil say that the regions of Tadoba and Gothangaon have been seeing a steady rise in tourists. “15 years ago, many did not know about Tadoba; the tiger reserve had over 25 tigers then. Now, it has over 100, and people are getting a real taste of wildlife tourism,” says Arjun.

Umred Pauni Karhandla, in particular, benefits from its unique location, he adds. “It lies exactly between Tadoba and Pench, right

(Clockwise from left) Tigress Junabai with her cubs at the Tadoba-Andhari Tiger Reserve; cubs of tigress Bubbly; and white-throated kingfisher in Tadoba. SHARATH UG AND BHUVANESH CHANDAR



along the Wainganga River. This space, spanning 189 square kilometres, acts as a great place for tigers to disperse. It is part of the Eastern Vidarbha tiger corridor, and if a tiger decides to leave its natural territory and move out, Umred Pauni Karhandla is a great place where they can halt, explore the region, take over territory, or push out older males,” says Arjun, adding that the presence of around 36 large water bodies, apart from the backwaters of the river, also makes it a birding hotspot. “Last year, while going on safaris around the conservancy, we recorded around 360 species of birds – migratory, passage visitors, resident birds, and summer visitors,” he adds.

As we speak, there are six breeding females with cubs at the wildlife sanctuary, like Fairy, Collarwali, X-Mark, F1, F2 and Shadow. “Breeding females indicate the health of an ecosystem. If prey density isn’t strong, breeding wouldn’t happen,” says Arjun,

adding that Shadow’s daughter from the first litter is expected to become the seventh breeding female soon. “The region also has male tigers like M4, J-Mark and Patil.”

It was well past 10pm when I wrapped up my interviews, and Sunil, packing his safari gear in a jiffy, asked me to hurry up and tag along – someone had notified his team of a call near the Nature conservancy, and Sunil was positive that it was F2 with her cubs. After two safaris at Tadoba and Gothangaon and a two-hour road trip between, one should have retired to their

room. But the prospect of seeing a magnificent tigress, with her cubs, in the thick of the dark, jolted me awake. Perhaps Sunil was not exaggerating – tiger safaris can narcotise one as much as a Sachin Tendulkar cover drive.



The writer was in Tadoba and Gothangaon at the invitation of Bamboo Forest safari lodge.

Indie frame of mind



Shuffling Suitcases brings Spring/Summer collections by 20 indie brands to Chennai

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Shuffling Suitcases, a multi-designer platform promoting India’s homegrown and conscious fashion labels since 2017, will bring its travelling pop-up to Chennai.

The two-day showcase of Spring/Summer collections includes apparel, jewellery (made of reclaimed textiles, metal and wood) and bags, by labels like Yam and Khara Kapas from Delhi; House of Kiyaara and Khyati Rughani from Mumbai; Raw India from Jaipur; Karishma Kajaria and Xaal Xuta from Kolkata; and Junaita and Aloe House from Chennai.

Devyani Kapoor, founder of Shuffling Suitcases, says, “Envisaged as a niche pop-up catering to working professionals, women in the age group of 35 to 65, we will be presenting over 20 brands for the Chennai edition,” she says.

The showcase is designed to appeal to a growing base of design-conscious consumers seeking clothing and accessories that balance functionality with contemporary aesthetics. The Chennai edition, says Devyani, reflects the platform’s focus on bringing diverse design voices under one roof, while responding to the city’s appreciation for craftsmanship.

At The Folly, Amethyst, Royapettah. March 28 and 29, 11am to 7pm. Entry is free.

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An incoherent bore



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In *Ustaad Bhagat Singh*, the director rehashes the outdated template of *Gabbar Singh*, and infuses it with a heavy dose of ideology that powers actor-politician Pawan Kalyan today. The result is a narrative that appears to be randomly stitched together to tick a few boxes on a checklist.

The story is strictly perfunctory. One does not go to a Harish Shankar and Pawan Kalyan film expecting an out-of-the-box narrative. But then, even fan service warrants coherence in storytelling. The film begins with snapshots of a covert operation as political fortunes in a State turn upside down, and goes back in time to unravel the origin story of the protagonist.

A boy who grows up in the jungle is adopted by the village headmaster (KS Ravikumar). He is inspired by teachings of Bhagavad Gita and the story of Bhagat Singh. It is a matter of time before the guru names him Bhagat Singh. The guru, who chooses to remain a bachelor, is called upon to join politics and serve the people of the State. He in turn, makes the boy promise that he, too, will give up everything and join the line of duty when asked to. This is just one of the many attempts to draw parallels to real-life references.

The bond between this guru and the protagonist is the foil within which a story of a fearless cop plays out. The cop is on a ‘clean and green’ mission. He decimates the nexus between a drug cartel and political heavyweights, punishes perpetrators of sexual assault, imparts tough lessons to those who disrespect religious sentiments and the Indian Army. These events are narrated in a disjointed and convenient manner.

The treatment of *Ustaad Bhagat Singh* is similar to the mainstream cinema of a decade or two ago. Neither the writing nor the technical departments bring in anything new.

In a film where the broad story becomes pointless after a while, it is not a surprise that the female characters are just meant to be decorative. If Raashii Khanna is shortchanged with a superfluous characterisation, Sree Leela’s does not rise above the chatty, bubbly trope. The romance between Sree Leela and Pawan Kalyan tries to give the story some emotional depth, but the age gap is glaring.

In the later portions of the film, the overdose of pandering to religious sentiments sticks out sorely. A sub plot on the lines of the ‘Nirbhaya’ incident reeks of voyeurism, as dialogues and visuals keep cutting back to the gruesome incident with a perpetual male gaze.

When the film emphasises on sindoor as a nod to Operation Sindoor, we know that the makers are finally done with their checklist and the story will be wrapped up.

Pawan Kalyan’s previous outing, *They Call Him OG*, at least boasted of a distinct style that made the film watchable. This one is a test of endurance.

Ustaad Bhagat Singh is currently playing in theatres.



A loud spectacle that doesn’t breathe

Ranveer Singh’s soul-baring performance salvages Aditya Dhar’s exhausting revenge saga, which doubles down on propaganda and pugnacity

Hindi

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Early in this maximalist’s dream of sensory overload, when the background voice of a girl menacingly provokes: ‘you are not ready for this’, one wants to tell her actually, one is over-prepared. As it turns out, the sequel attempts to outdo the original in volume and venom, perhaps at the expense of the original’s narrative weight. One went for a story, returned with a migraine and a beard. Dhar is the master of frame and fireworks, but he loses sight of the clock and control. Perhaps, deliberately. Channelling the mood of the moment, when the world is itching for war, he feeds the bloodlust of a section of the masses, ensuring a box-office bonanza but setting a dangerous precedent.

The exhausting revenge saga that mistakes length for depth picks up right after the first film’s climax, with undercover Indian agent Jaskirat Singh Rangī (Ranveer Singh), now deeply embedded as Hamza Ali Mazari, rising to dominate Karachi’s Lyari underworld following the death of gang leader Rehman Dakait (Akshaye Khanna).

Fuelled by personal tragedy and pumped up by Ajay Sanyal’s (R. Madhavan) radicalisation, Hamza consolidates power amid gang wars, shifting alliances, corrupt officials, and escalating threats from SP Chaudhary Aslam (Sanjay Dutt) and ISI operative Major Iqbal (Arjun Rampal), the mastermind behind terror networks targeting India.

As he infiltrates deeper into Pakistan’s criminal-terror-political nexus, the mission blurs into a brutal personal vendetta, forcing Hamza to dismantle funding routes, eliminate key enemies, and for a moment confront the psychological toll of living as a monster for his country.

The film’s strongest hook is Ranveer’s performance. After being overshadowed by Akshaye in the first part and reduced to

Dhurandhar: The Revenge

Director: Aditya Dhar

Cast: Ranveer Singh, Sara Arjun, Arjun Rampal, Sanjay Dutt, Rakesh Bedi

Storyline: Following the brutal fallout of the first mission, Jaskirat/ Hamza is thrust into a sprawling mission of retribution dotted with deep-state conspiracy

furniture by the demands of the character that expected him to be largely one note, here the actor flexes all his muscles, shifting seamlessly between vulnerability, cold calculation, and unhinged ferocity to carry the nearly 4-hour runtime almost single-handedly as a home-grown Rambo.

Drenched in odious emotion where savagery is the screenplay, for the most part, it works like an explainer of the first part, an answer to those who mocked Dhar’s peak detailing. Dhar’s style leans heavily on gratuitous violence, creating a world so relentlessly brutal that it seems the makers want the audience to become desensitised to the stakes and focus on the blood-curdling sequences. It feels more like an extended web series than a tight theatrical film, with indulgent sequences that impede mood and momentum.

In this game of cause and effect, the focus is on effect. If you take out the addictive background score, the mise-en-scene runs the risk of getting reduced to twenty ways to maim or decapitate the enemy. The language increasingly descends into the gutter, and the motive seems to justify the government’s controversial policy decisions, such as demonetisation.

An example of storytelling embedded in a political manifesto, the film’s heart beats for the right side of the political ecosystem. This time it serves like a mouthpiece of the ruling regime even more unabashedly by deliberately confusing Indians with Hindus, blurring the line between Pakistani and Indian Muslims, and painting the Opposition and non-governmental organisations as if they are in cahoots with the neighbour’s terror network. However, towards the end, when the makers tell us that we have our agents functioning in Pakistan’s political setup for more than 40 years, it goes against their own ‘chai-wallah’ narrative of mythical proportions.

Faithfully reproducing the ruling establishment’s playbook on security, nationalism, and enemies, the film lionises aggressive counter-terror operations, surgical strikes, and dismantling of terror networks – framing them as moral necessities. More importantly, it tends to commodify national grief from terror attacks into

entertainment while reinforcing divisive binaries. The focus on Pakistan reminds one of those dramatic news stories on electronic media, mounted to divert attention from domestic politics to the goings-on in the neighbourhood.

While entertaining and rooted in documented events, it risks simplifying complex geopolitics into black-and-white jingoism. The sequence of events works like a documentation of the claims on ‘New India’ made in political speeches where Indian intelligence agencies conduct covert operations in foreign countries and law enforcement agencies indulge in extra-judicial killings. It gives the thrill of what-if to a mass that seeks validation for its voting choices in cinema halls and wants to see the dramatisation of the manufactured rage of social media as big-screen entertainment.

The much hyped Bade Sahab bit turns out to be a much-flogged Dawood Ibrahim horse that has run its course. In fact, for a film that prides itself on walking the fine line between reel and real, some of the conjectures towards the end are laughable.

Rampal is solid but doesn’t carry the charisma and gravitas of Akshaye’s Rehman. Sanjay Dutt retains his swagger, and Rakesh Bedi generates rare moments of levity amidst the bloodbath. Honey trapped in the first part; Sara Arjun as Yalina has been given the task of upholding humanity in a testosterone-rich environment, and she gives a good account of a trope drenched in tears and sobs.

Sashwat Sachdev’s soundtrack doesn’t match the energy of the first part. Repurposed old songs such as Boney M’s *Rasputin*, Bappi Lahiri’s *Tamma Tamma*, and Kalyanji Anandji’s *Tirchi Topiwala* are fun in spots but feel more slapped than organic. They evoke more respect for the original creators rather than Sachdev’s creativity.

In the end, riding on Ranveer’s leonine performance, *Dhurandhar 2* roars, but in its deafening cocktail of patriotism and propaganda, it forgets the quiet cost of humanity, leaving little space for reflection.

Dhurandhar: The Revenge is currently running in theatres

Ken Karunaas shines in a cheeky coming-of-age entertainer

Tamil

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In Vetri Maaran’s 2019 action drama *Asuran*, Dhanush’s Sivasamy signs off with a cautionary tale for his son Chidambaram, played by Ken Karunaas, about education being the sharpest weapon against social hierarchy. Seven years later, it’s now Chidambaram’s time to stand for education. Ken directs and stars in *Youth*, a coming-of-age entertainer that speaks the tongue of new-gen youth and champions education. And Ken does it in a playful tone and with a familiar mainstream template we have seen before – he makes a film for, about, and from the perspective of his targeted audiences (high schoolers) and slips in his moral lesson like a doctor distracting a child to administer a needle.

The film has a disarmingly slight story, neutral and universal in plot. It follows a troubleshooting 10th grader,



Praveen (Ken), who lives a carefree, bratty school life, to the dismay of his father, Unnikrishnan, and is almost undeserving of the trust of his dotting mother, Saroja. “Finding the love of my life is my only goal,” he declares, as he whiles away pursuing the girls he crosses paths with, from his school to the terrace of his home. But the unthinkable happens one fine day: he meets Preshika (Meenakshi Dinesh), another brat from his adjacent classroom, and it’s an instant match

made in heaven.

What is even more special? He got the girl to propose to him. But what if I say that the god he prays to is a god who keeps on giving. One fine day, he gets a Facebook text from a girl named Sonal, and it turns out this isn’t a fake account, but rather, a real girl, sweet-looking with a twinkle in her eye (Priyanshi Yadav), who soon confesses that she is head-over-heels in love with Praveen.

But what goes up must come

down. Praveen suffers a double heartbreak with Preshika and Sonal. Everything goes awry. So is this film just about Ken and his school life? Earlier in the film, we see his parents, Saroja (Devadarshini) and Unnikrishnan (Suraj Venjaramoodu), suffer humiliation at the hands of their relatives. This detail is planted early on to show that there’s an overarching layer to *Youth*, one that is sure to make you smile.

Nothing about *Youth* is pressing or unprecedented – nothing extraordinary ever happens, and the template is followed to the T. Every school might have many Praveens who go through similar experiences. Even the third act seems like a legend you hear from your school seniors.

But *Youth* revels in celebrating the highs and humiliations, joys and jitters, and the innocence and disillusionment of high school life. Watching Praveen and his unruly gang engage in shenanigans made me think of the many colourful characters from my high school. There’s an over-the-topness that seems almost proudly indecent – boy

gang throwbacks are seldom civil.

Youth compels your undivided attention when Ken moves on to show the equation between Praveen’s parents. Suraj and Devadarshini deliver clean performances, and the arc reminds us what parenthood in the 21st century is all about. Be it a dialogue between them about happiness or how organic the dynamics between Unni, Saroja, and Praveen seem...Ken reminds us that he isn’t

his character, and therefore, quite mature.

There is a moment in the third act that made me pause a bit. Praveen tells someone that perhaps true love comes without any expectations, one that backs you no matter what, like a parent who wouldn’t ever give up on their child. While it feels like an outdated aspiration, an impractical pressure on love, I’m reminded that this comes from a 24-year-old writing a teenager’s coming-of-age.

Love, if anything, evolves with the meaning we give to it. At one stage, it can mean to be with someone who truly understands you, an expectation that fades when you realise that there’s more to it than just that. For Praveen, a girl should love as your parents do, and that is okay to believe at that age. And so, perhaps the most beautiful thing about *Youth* is that both Ken and Praveen allow themselves to be who they are. They are imperfect and evolving, as we all are.

Youth is currently running in theatres

Peaky Blinders: The Immortal Man

Director: Tom Harper

Cast: Cillian Murphy, Sophie Rundle, Ned Dennehy, Packy Lee, Ian Peck, Stephen Graham, Rebecca Ferguson, Tim Roth, Jay Lycurgo, and Barry Keoghan

Synopsis: In 1940, as the Second World War engulfs Europe, Tommy Shelby finds himself back in the streets of Small Heath, Birmingham, for a final fight



Farewell to Tommy Shelby

English

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It has been less than half a decade since Tommy Shelby bid adieu to our screens in 2022. Four years later, Cillian Murphy returns as the Birmingham gangster, to give his final farewell in *Peaky Blinders: The Immortal Man*. The film serves almost exclusively as a vehicle to provide Tommy with a proper goodbye, but the signature *Peaky Blinders* beats still manage to deliver a thrilling film.

In 1940, Tommy Shelby has sheltered himself away from the Birmingham alleys he once ruled,

in a remote mansion, with only Johnny Dogs (Packy Lee) for company. It is also the year when the Nazis are spreading their war across Europe. But away from all this, Tommy's daily routine now features him poring over the autobiography he is writing. When not doing that, the retired gangster finds himself being tormented by the deaths of his brother Arthur and his daughter Ruby.

Meanwhile in Birmingham, Tommy's son Duke (Barry Keoghan) has taken over the *Peaky Blinders*, and fashioning himself (quite literally) after his father. But much to his aunt Ada's chagrin (Sophie Rundle) he is also raiding munitions factories, and stealing morphine from hospitals. When Nazi footsteps reach the Garrison Pub, as John Beckett (Tim Roth) attempts to rope in Duke in the plan to make Britain lose the war, it finally sends alarm bells ringing all the way to Tommy's cottage.

A visit from Zelda's sister Kaulo (Rebecca Ferguson) manages to stir Tommy enough, as he races back to Birmingham to take part in his final battle against the Nazis. He is going to save his son from

himself, save Britain from the fascists, and go out in a blaze of glory. Spoiler alert: he does, but not before some serious self-referencing that dishes out enough majestic scenes, and broody dialogues to serve the *Peaky Blinders* fans twice over.

Besides the timeline, there is not much new on offer from the film. But that does not mean it's all bad. Steven Knight's screenplay, predictable enough, is made interesting because of how it approaches the nostalgia around the show. It is just self-mythologising enough to be reverent of its successful past, but stops short of completely losing sight of the future.

Peaky Blinders: The Immortal Man is a farewell tour tailored for Tommy Shelby. Its tragic, bloody and muddies the streets of Small Heath. Along the way, it appears to pass the baton to a new generation of the Shelby family. *The Immortal Man* is a decent detour, but it remains to be seen what Steven Knight intends to expand upon this legacy.

Peaky Blinders: The Immortal Man is streaming on Netflix.

Snippets



Kunal Kemmu and Preity Zinta team up for the action-comedy Vibe

Kunal Kemmu and Preity Zinta will be teaming up for the upcoming action-comedy, *Vibe*. Written and directed by Kemmu, the film also features Sparsh Shrivastava and Vanshika Dhir in pivotal roles.

The film was announced as part of Prime Video's slate of 2026 and will be released theatrically under Amazon MGM Studios. Its synopsis reads, "A clueless slacker and his by-the-book best friend — two men who can barely manage their own lives — find the fate of the nation in their hands when they accidentally stumble into a terrorist plot."

Vibe has been produced by Kunal and Chirag Nihalani under their banner Drongo Films. Kunal made his directorial debut in 2024 with *Madgaon Express*.



Mohanlal to feature in Priyadarshan's 100th film

Malayalam superstar Mohanlal will be reuniting with filmmaker Priyadarshan for a currently untitled film, the makers announced recently. It will mark the 100th film of Priyadarshan and is backed by Mohanlal's longtime collaborator, Antony Perumbavoor of Aashirvad Cinemas.

Mohanlal took to social media to make the announcement as he wrote a long note about his association with Priyadarshan. The actor said that such milestones belong not just to one person but to everyone who witnessed the journey up-close.

He had also starred Priyadarshan's debut film, *Poochakkoru Mookkuthi* in 1984.



Dilkashi: First look from Lijo Jose Pellissery's Hindi debut unveiled

Acclaimed Malayalam director Lijo Jose Pellissery will be making his Hindi directorial debut with *Dilkashi*. Backed by Hansal Mehta and Sahil Saigal, the film stars Abhay Verma and Zahaan Kapoor.

The movie is written by Karan Vyas & Lijo. The film features music by AR Rahman.

A first look from the film was unveiled on March 19 at Prime Video's 2026 slate announcement. It features Abhay with a girl in the backdrop of Mumbai's popular buildings.

The film tells the story of Rose and Atharva, who reunite in a seductive game of love, betrayal, fantasy, and dangerously irreversible second chances.



Kindest lie money can buy

From staged funerals to rented fatherhood, Brendan Fraser turns rented intimacy into something disarmingly real in Hikari's poignant Tokyo fable

English, Japanese

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Of course there are companies where you can rent a husband, a daughter, a wedding guest, a videogame partner, or just someone to clap for you at karaoke. Only in Japan could loneliness evolve into something this efficiently organised — it is exactly the kind of thing us 'gaijin' describe as "so Japanese" while secretly wondering why no one else thought to formalise emotional outsourcing with this level of commitment. Werner Herzog took one look at this ecosystem in his 2019 quasi-documentary *Family Romance, LLC*, about actors hired to impersonate loved ones, and spiralled into metaphysical dread. But Japanese filmmaker Hikari saw the opportunity for something warmer, even a little seductive, because she understood the one fatal flaw in any philosophical objection to this business model: Brendan Fraser. After all, who would say no to a day drifting through Tokyo with one of the world's most kind faces?

Rental Family opens on Fraser's Phillip Vandarploeg, an American actor who moved to Tokyo years earlier for a fleeting commercial success as a toothpaste mascot, and the residue of that minor fame lingers in the corners of his life. Philip is a man who has learned how to occupy space in Tokyo without quite belonging to it, and Fraser plays him with a transparency that turns this condition into a plot engine as well as a liability, because every role he accepts within the film's premise asks him to simulate intimacy while the film itself struggles to examine what that simulation costs him in return.

Hikari stages this strange Japanese industry with a functional clarity, allowing Phillip's entry into the titular agency as the "token white man" to unravel through a series of assignments that range from absurd to the ethically loaded. His first job as a mourner at a faux funeral establishes

Rental Family

Director: Hikari

Cast: Brendan Fraser, Takehiro Hira, Mari Yamamoto, Shannon Mahina Gorman, and Akira Emoto

Storyline: Struggling to find purpose, an American actor lands an unusual gig with a Japanese rental agency to play stand-in roles for strangers

the tone, since the revelation that the deceased is alive frames grief as a performance, while also giving Phillip a mirror he does not fully confront. From there, the film moves through weddings, companionship gigs, and other small acts of emotional labour that position the service as a pragmatic response to loneliness in a society infamous for their inability to directly confront vulnerability.

Phillip approaches each assignment with the earnestness of someone who wants to do the job well without entirely understanding its implications. When Phillip agrees to pose as the estranged father of an 11-year-old girl named Mia, the narrative finds its most durable throughline, since the arrangement requires him to maintain a fiction over time, to earn the trust of a child who believes in his presence.

This progression unfolds alongside a second long-term assignment in which Phillip poses as a journalist interviewing an aging actor suffering from memory loss, and the parallel is not subtle, since both roles require him to validate another person's sense of self through sustained attention. There is a metatextual undercurrent here, as Fraser shares the frame with a character confronting obsolescence, inviting us to fold his own career's long detours and returns into the exchange. The cumulative effect of these storylines produces a steady accrual of sentiment that aligns with Hikari's directorial instincts.

The film's visual approach reinforces this orientation, as Takuro Ishizaka's cinematography renders Tokyo in bright, even light that resists the nocturnal Citypop stylisations often associated with the city, and this choice situates Phillip's experiences within a recognisable everyday environment rather than some exoticised backdrop. The surface then feels inviting and coherent, though it also contributes to the film's tendency to smooth over the more difficult questions embedded in its premise, particularly those concerning consent, deception, and the long-term effects of manufactured relationships.

Hikari's script acknowledges these tensions in passing, especially through the character of Mari Yamamoto's Aiko, a co-worker whose assignments expose the

harsher edges of the industry, yet the film does not pursue her perspective with the same persistence it grants Phillip, which creates an imbalance that narrows the scope of its inquiry. Takehiro Hira's Shinji, who manages the agency with a mix of pragmatism and detachment, introduces a counterpoint that frames the work as a necessary service, though later revelations of his own reliance on rented relationships complicates that stance in ways the film sketches without fully developing. These elements only signal towards a more layered exploration of the system's internal contradictions, but the narrative remains oriented toward Phillip's personal journey, which it resolves through saccharine gestures of growth that feel emotionally loaded even when they leave broader questions intact.

Pop culture has decided to protect Brendan Fraser at all costs, and it is easy to see why, since his screen persona offers an unguarded emotional availability that feels almost out of step with the present moment. Even after the industry ceremonially welcomed him back with an Oscar for *The Whale*, what lingers is how the man still carries that faintly rumpled, open-hearted quality that made him impossible to dislike in the first place. There is a wistfulness to his face, a sense that every smile has travelled through something to get there, and a slight hesitation in his body language, as if checking that the other person is alright before proceeding, yet none of it curdles into self-pity or performance. His endless capacity to give is a rare instinct in an industry built on extraction, and it explains why even his most uneven projects tend to inherit a baseline of goodwill simply by having him at the centre of them.

Hikari has made a modest, carefully shaped drama that understands the appeal of its premise and the strengths of its charismatic lead. While it leaves certain complexities at the edges of its frame, the film sustains a steady engagement with the human desire to be seen, which gives its most effective moments a poignant, sentimental clarity that lingers on.

Rental Family is currently streaming on JioHotstar